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Cancelled, Not Retired

Does a Rising Cancellation Rate Anticipate a Service's End?

Marek Solheim · Anouk Mensah · Verity Marris — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

The University counts every print-credit top-up cancellation as a "self-service resolution" — the same tag a successful top-up earns. Does a rising cancel rate ever register as a service nearing its end, or does the tag erase the difference?

Aims

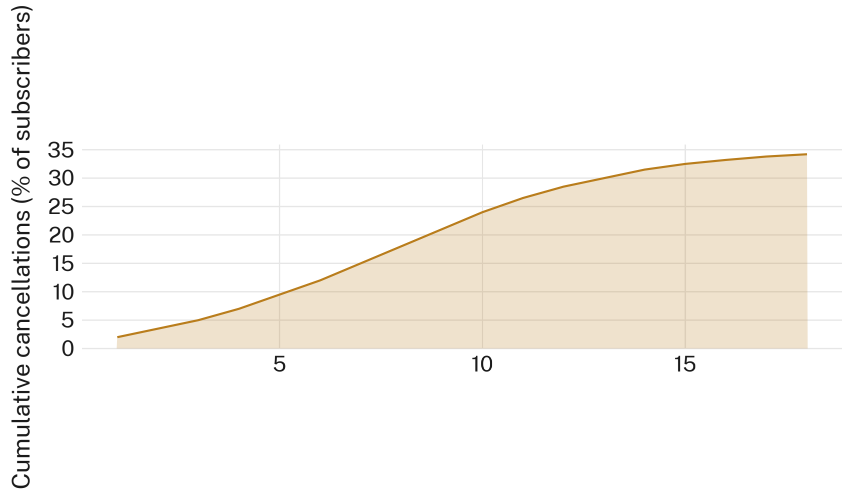
- Test whether the top-up service's current cancellation trajectory matches the pattern seen before four other campus subscription-style services were retired.
- Determine whether the self-service-resolution metric distinguishes an opt-out from an ordinary successful top-up.
- Identify whether a rising cancellation rate could function as a retirement signal rather than an engagement win.

Methods

- 18-month cancellation logs, print-credit top-up service ($n = 4,180$ active subscribers, month 1) vs. four retired campus subscription-style services' final 18 months
- monthly cumulative cancellation share, aligned on months before discontinuation
- ticketing logs cross-tabulated against the "self-service resolution" tag; no distinct opt-out code found in either dataset

Results & analysis

Print-credit cancellations climbed from 2% to 34% of active subscribers over eighteen months, tracking the 30–35% band in which three of the four comparator services were formally discontinued. No cancellation in either dataset carried a resolution tag distinct from a completed top-up.



Cumulative print-credit cancellations passed 30% of active subscribers in month 13 and reached 34% by month 18 (June 2026) — the range at which three of the four comparator services were discontinued.

Interpretation

Suggestive, not diagnostic — four retirements is a thin comparator set, and the resolution tag still can't tell decline from delight.

Next: a distinct "opted out entirely" code, piloted before the rate reaches the historical range.

Selected references

1. Gray et al. (2018). The Dark (Patterns) Side of UX Design. *CHI 2018*, 1–14. doi:10.1145/3173574.3174108
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3. Scheffer et al. (2009). Early-warning signals for critical transitions. *Nature* 461, 53–59. doi:10.1038/nature08227
4. Verbeke et al. (2012). New insights into churn prediction in the telecom sector. *Eur. J. Oper. Res.* 218(1), 211–229. doi:10.1016/j.ejor.2011.09.031
5. Bass (1969). A new product growth for model consumer durables. *Mgmt. Sci.* 15(5), 215–227. doi:10.1287/mnsc.15.5.215

Cancellation logs de-identified at extraction; comparator-service records drawn from Facilities and Digital Services archives, no subscriber correspondence retained.